RESIDE IN KANSAS CITY

A FREE GUIDE FOR FAMILIES

The Kansas City *Inherited Home* Guide

A calm, step-by-step plan for what to do with a house you've inherited, on either side of the state line.

Jarred Donalson, REALTOR®

Keller Williams KC North

Cell 816-719-0829 · Office 816-452-4200

jarred.donalson@kw.com · resideinkc.com

BEFORE YOU START

A Note From Jarred

If you're reading this, you've probably lost someone important, and now a house is part of what they left behind. That's a lot to carry at once.

The good news is that you don't have to figure it all out this week. **Making a plan early is the single most important thing you can do to make this process less stressful.**

Before I became a REALTOR®, I worked as a therapist. Those years taught me how to help people through hard seasons and big transitions, and I bring that same patience to every family I work with. When a home carries this many memories, the conversations matter as much as the paperwork.

This guide walks you through that plan one step at a time: what to do first, what can wait, and what your options really are.

What's inside

Step 1	The First 30 Days
Step 2	Understand How the House Passes to You
Step 3	Know Your Options
Step 4	Clearing Out the House
Step 5	Making Decisions with Siblings or Co-Heirs
Step 6	Taxes and Costs to Ask About
Step 7	A Simple Timeline and Your Checklist

> This guide is for general information only. It isn't legal, tax or financial advice. Every estate is different, so please talk with a probate attorney and a CPA about your specific situation.

STEP 1

The First 30 Days

The first month is about protecting the house and getting organized, not making big decisions.

Do these first

- **Secure the home.** Lock all doors and windows. Think about changing the locks if you aren't sure who has keys.
- **Keep the insurance active.** Call the homeowner's insurance company and let them know the owner has passed. Some policies change or lapse when a home is vacant, so ask about vacancy coverage.
- **Keep the utilities on.** Keep power, water and gas on so the house doesn't freeze, mold or get damaged. Kansas City winters are hard on empty houses.
- **Forward the mail.** Bills, tax notices and mortgage statements will tell you a lot about what's owed.
- **Find the paperwork.** Look for a will, a trust, the deed, mortgage statements, property tax bills and insurance policies.
- **Check the property regularly.** Walk through at least once a week, or ask a neighbor you trust to keep an eye on it.

Hold off on these for now

- Don't sell, give away or throw out valuables before you know who has the legal right to decide.
- Don't sign anything to sell the house until you know who has the authority to sell it.
- Don't start expensive repairs or renovations yet.
- Don't accept the first cash offer that shows up in the mailbox. More on that in Step 3.

STEP 2

Understand How the House Passes to You

Before anyone can sell, rent or move into the home, you need to know how ownership legally transfers. There are usually a few common paths.

If there's a trust

If the home was placed in a living trust, the named trustee can usually manage or sell it without going through probate court. This is often the simplest path.

If there's a transfer-on-death or beneficiary deed

Missouri and Kansas both allow a deed that names who receives the home when the owner dies. If one was recorded, the home may pass to the named beneficiary without probate.

If there's a will, or no will at all

In many cases, the home goes through **probate**. This is the court process that confirms who inherits and gives someone, usually called the personal representative or executor, the legal authority to act for the estate.

Some smaller estates may qualify for a simplified process. The rules, dollar limits and timelines are different in Missouri and Kansas, and they can change. A local probate attorney can tell you quickly which path fits your situation.

Why this matters for selling

If probate is required, the house generally can't be sold until the court has given someone authority to sell. Knowing this early helps you set a realistic timeline.

A REAL KANSAS CITY STORY

Two sisters, one canceled listing

Two sisters inherited their parents' home after their mother passed away. The house was dated and needed some mild repairs. They first listed it with an agent who didn't realize the home had to go through probate before it could be sold. No buyer could close, so the listing was canceled.

After probate was complete, they called me. The market favored sellers, so we made only the repairs needed for the home to qualify for government-backed loans like FHA and VA. Then we marketed it well, and it sold for over asking price within a couple of days.

"Knowing the process up front saves families time, money and a lot of frustration."

JARRED DONALSON, REALTOR®

STEP 3

Know Your Options

There's no single right answer. The best choice depends on your finances, your family, the condition of the house and how much time and energy you have.

01
Keep the home and live in it

GOOD FIT IF

You or a family member wants to live there and can take on the payments, taxes and upkeep.

THINK ABOUT

Any mortgage still owed, buying out co-heirs and the cost of updates.

02
Keep it as a rental

GOOD FIT IF

The home is in solid shape, sits in a good rental area and you're comfortable being a landlord or hiring a property manager.

THINK ABOUT

Repairs before renting, insurance changes, management costs and agreement among heirs.

03
Sell it as-is

GOOD FIT IF

You live out of town, the house needs a lot of work, or the family wants a simpler and faster process.

THINK ABOUT

You'll usually trade some price for speed and convenience. An as-is sale listed on the open market often brings more than a quick cash offer.

04
Make light updates, then sell

GOOD FIT IF

The house is basically sound but dated, and you have some time and money to invest.

THINK ABOUT

Focus on updates buyers pay for, like paint, flooring, deep cleaning, landscaping and small repairs. Skip big remodels.

A word about "we buy houses" offers. After a death, families often get letters and calls from cash buyers. Some are fair, but many are well below market value. Before you accept any offer, get a real market value for the home so you know what you'd be giving up.

STEP 4

Clearing Out the House

For most families, this is the hardest part, emotionally and physically. Give yourself grace.

A simple order to follow

1. **Find important documents and valuables first.** Look for wills, titles, financial records, jewelry, photos and anything with sentimental value.
2. **Let family choose keepsakes.** Set a date and a simple system for who gets what, so it feels fair.
3. **Decide what to sell.** Furniture, tools, collectibles and household goods can often be sold through an estate sale.
4. **Donate what's left.** Many local charities will pick up usable items.
5. **Haul away the rest.** A junk removal company can handle the final cleanout.

Estate sale help

An experienced estate sale company can price, stage, sell and clear out belongings, often in just a few days.

TRUSTED PARTNER

Nine Estate Sales

If you need a recommendation, I've worked with Nine Estate Sales and I'm happy to connect you.

STEP 5

Making Decisions with Siblings or Co-Heirs

When more than one person inherits a home, disagreements are common. Usually it's not because anyone is being difficult. People simply have different needs, memories and timelines.

What helps

- **Agree on who's in charge.** Usually this is the personal representative or trustee, but everyone should know who makes the final call.
- **Get the facts first.** A market value, a repair estimate and a list of monthly carrying costs give everyone the same starting point.
- **Talk through the options together.** Use the four options in Step 3 as the agenda.
- **Put decisions in writing.** A short email summary after each conversation prevents misunderstandings later.
- **Plan for a buyout.** If one person wants to keep the house, a fair market value makes a buyout much easier to discuss.

If the family is truly stuck, an attorney or mediator can help you find a path forward.

STEP 6

Taxes and Costs to Ask About

Talk with a CPA before you sell, but here are the topics worth raising.

- **Step-up in basis.** Inherited property often receives a "stepped-up" cost basis to its value at the date of death, which can greatly reduce capital gains tax when you sell. Ask your CPA how this applies to you.
- **Holding costs.** Property taxes, insurance, utilities, lawn care and any mortgage payments keep adding up while the home sits.
- **Any mortgage or liens.** These are usually paid off from the sale proceeds at closing.
- **Probate and attorney costs.** Ask up front how fees are structured.
- **Selling costs.** These include commissions, title fees and any repairs or concessions.

> This section is general information, not tax advice. Please consult a qualified CPA or tax professional.

STEP 7

A Simple Timeline

Every estate moves at its own pace. Here's a general picture of how it often goes.

Weeks 1–4	Secure the home, keep insurance and utilities on, gather documents
Months 1–2	Talk with a probate attorney, learn how the home transfers, get a market value
Months 2–4	Decide your option as a family and begin clearing out the house
Months 3–6+	Make light updates if needed, list and sell, or move forward with keeping or renting

Probate timelines vary widely, so your attorney can give you a more specific picture.

KEEP THIS HANDY

Your Inherited Home Checklist

Print this page and check things off as you go.

First 30 days

- [ ] Secure the home and change locks if needed
- [ ] Notify the insurance company and ask about vacancy coverage
- [ ] Keep utilities on
- [ ] Forward the mail
- [ ] Find the will, trust, deed, mortgage and tax documents

Next steps

- [ ] Meet with a probate attorney
- [ ] Confirm who has authority to sell or manage the home
- [ ] Get a market value for the home
- [ ] Talk with co-heirs about the options
- [ ] Talk with a CPA about taxes

Getting the house ready

- [ ] Remove important documents and valuables
- [ ] Let family choose keepsakes
- [ ] Schedule an estate sale
- [ ] Donate and haul away the rest
- [ ] Decide on any light updates

HOW I CAN HELP

You don't have to do this alone.

I've helped many Kansas City families sell an inherited home, and I know how heavy it can feel. Before real estate, I worked as a therapist, so I understand that this is about more than a house.

Here's what I can do for you, with no pressure and no obligation:

- Give you an honest market value, so you know your real options
- Help you compare selling as-is with making light updates
- Connect you with trusted local partners, including estate sale, cleanout and repair pros
- Coordinate the sale, even if you live out of town
- Keep everyone in the family informed along the way

Whenever you're ready, reach out. We'll start with a simple plan.

Jarred Donalson, REALTOR®

RESIDE IN KANSAS CITY · KELLER WILLIAMS KC NORTH

Licensed in Missouri and Kansas

816-719-0829

Office 816-452-4200

jarred.donalson@kw.com

resideinkc.com

Keller Williams KC North, 310 NW Englewood Rd, Kansas City, MO 64118 · 816-452-4200. Each Keller Williams office is independently owned and operated. This guide is for general information only and is not legal, tax or financial advice. Please consult a probate attorney, CPA or other qualified professional about your specific situation.